



Lighthouse Reef

Great blue hole

Location Western Caribbean

Type Ridge reef

Total area 116 sq miles (300 sq km)

Lighthouse Reef lies off the coast of Belize in Central America. It did not form on an extinct volcano. Instead, it has developed on a ridge of limestone, drowned by rising sea levels as continental ice sheets melted at the end of the last ice age. The sea

has flooded limestone caves that formed when the ridge was dry land. In the middle of the reef, the roof of one of these caves has collapsed to create the Great Blue Hole—a deep, dark, submerged pit in the shallow, pale blue lagoon.



Kure Atoll

Ring of coral

Location Hawaiian islands, Pacific

Type Atoll of volcanic origin

Total area 31 sq miles (80 sq km)

Kure is the oldest part of the island chain that includes Hawaii. It was once an active volcano, but has been extinct and sinking for so long—25 million years—that today the volcano has vanished. It has left behind just a ring of coral around a shallow lagoon. The only large sandy island on the atoll is a nesting site for thousands of seabirds.

Maldives

Atolls within atolls

Location Northern Indian Ocean

Type Ridge reefs

Total area 3,475 sq miles (9,000 sq km)

Lying in the tropical Indian Ocean, the Maldives are a complex group of atolls that have formed on a ridge of volcanic rock extending south from India. Unusually, many of the atolls are chains of smaller atolls, and from space they look like strings of pearls floating in the blue ocean. The highest land is only 8 ft (2.4 m) above sea level.

▼ PERFECT CIRCLE

This jewel-like atoll is one of more than 1,192 islands forming the Maldives.



Aldabra

Mushroom islands

Location Western Indian Ocean

Type Raised atoll

Total area 60 sq miles (155 sq km)

One of the largest coral atolls, Aldabra is unusual because the forces that build mountains have pushed up the seabed beneath it, raising the reefs into the air. The sea has carved some of these raised reefs into small mushroom-shaped islands, such as the one shown below.

